

North African Spiced Shepherd's Pie

A harissa-spiced lentil and mushroom filling with a golden olive oil mash — warming, hearty, and even better the next day.

Serves 4

Ingredients

- 3 tbsp** olive oil
 - 1** leek, sliced
 - 2** celery stalks, diced
 - 2** carrots, diced
 - 3** garlic cloves, minced
 - 1 tsp** cumin seeds
 - 1 tsp** ground cumin
 - 2 tbsp** rose harissa paste
 - 200 g** mushrooms, roughly chopped
 - 150 g** green or brown lentils (dried)
 - 400 g** white beans (tinned, drained)
 - 400 g** tinned tomatoes
 - 300 ml** vegetable stock
 - 1 tbsp** miso paste
 - 0.5** lemon, juiced
 - 800 g** floury potatoes, peeled and chopped
 - 3 tbsp** olive oil (for mash)
 - 1 pinch** salt and black pepper
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Method

Step 1 — Cook the lentils

Rinse the lentils and simmer in plenty of water for 20–25 minutes until just tender but still holding their shape. Drain and set aside.

Step 2 — Build the base

Heat olive oil in a large pan over medium heat. Add cumin seeds and let them sizzle for 30 seconds, then add leek, celery and carrots. Cook for 8–10 minutes until softened.

Step 3 — Add garlic and spices

Add garlic, ground cumin and rose harissa paste. Stir well and cook for 2 minutes until fragrant.

Step 4 — Add mushrooms

Add mushrooms and cook for 5 minutes until they've released their moisture and started to colour.

Step 5 — Build the sauce

Add tinned tomatoes, vegetable stock and miso paste. Stir to combine, then add the cooked lentils and white beans. Simmer on a low heat for 15–20 minutes until thick and rich. It should not be sloppy — let it reduce properly. Finish with lemon juice and season well.

Step 6 — Make the mash

While the filling simmers, boil potatoes in salted water until tender, around 20 minutes. Drain thoroughly, then mash with olive oil and a splash of the cooking water if needed. Season generously. You want it smooth and spreadable but not too loose.

Step 7 — Assemble

Preheat oven to 200°C. Spoon the filling into a baking dish. Spread the mash over the top evenly, then rough up the surface with a fork to create ridges — these will catch and brown nicely. Drizzle a little extra olive oil over the top.

Step 8 — Bake

Bake for 25–30 minutes until the top is golden and the filling is bubbling at the edges. Rest for 5 minutes before serving.

Notes

The filling genuinely improves overnight as the harissa and spices develop. If reheating the next day, add a splash of water or stock before putting it back in the oven covered with foil, then uncover for the last 10 minutes to re-crisp the mash. You can add a little extra harissa on top of the mash before baking if you want more heat on the surface.